

the main window of Desktop Architect. This opens an interactive window that prompts you to choose the theme to be packaged. Choose the '.theme' file that you just created. Click on the 'Next' button to proceed and choose the type of file that you would like to create. Choose the 'Zip file/self installing package' option from the list. Click 'Next' to proceed. Finally click 'Finish'. Your theme is packaged and ready for distribution. Mail or upload it on your site so that your friends can access it too.

Randomising themes

It's more fun if the themes automatically change at a frequency of your choice. Desktop Architect allows you set a scheduled task enabling you to randomise wallpapers and themes.

Select 'Options' from the 'Tools' menu and click on the 'Scheduler' tab. In the window that comes up, click on the 'Add' button. Next, click on 'Item' and enter a name for your scheduled task. In the same window, select the frequency of the scheduled task in the 'Schedule Item'

dialog box.

Now click on the 'Advanced' button and in the 'Start date' dialog box, set the start date for the event. Select the 'Repeat item' checkbox and set the frequency of the event.

The 'Files' tab allows you to add themes and wallpapers. From the 'Type' drop down list, choose 'Themes'. You can add single files or an entire folder by clicking on the 'Add' button. In the 'Order' dialog box, set the cycling mode as Sequential or Random. Click 'OK' and close

all the popup windows until you see the main window.

Your scheduled event will now be triggered at the pre-set time and your theme will automatically change.

To test this, right-click on the Desktop Architect icon on the system tray, choose the 'Schedule' option, and click on 'Apply random theme now'.

This triggers the event and you will see that the theme changes automatically. In case it doesn't, back-track and edit your task to see what went wrong.

SHELL REPLACEMENTS

A shell is like an advanced skin/theme replacement—a theme allows you to vary only certain features, a shell allows you whole lot more flexibility

DesktopX

This shell replacement program extends the capabilities of Windows by adding extra objects on the desktop, which get animated if you do a mouse over to reveal the purpose of that object

Select an object and click on the 'Load' button to add it to your desktop.

Hiding taskbar and icons

Click on the DesktopX icon on the desktop to launch the configuration window. Choose 'Theme settings' from the options listed to the left.

In the 'Desktop' tab, tick the 'Hide explorer taskbar' and 'Hide desktop icons' checkboxes. Click 'Close' to apply changes. If you choose to reveal the desktop icons (which are hidden by default in DesktopX environment) it will result in a cluttered desktop. Leave the settings at default.

Adding new objects

Right-click on the DesktopX icon in the system tray or click on the DesktopX icon on the desktop to launch the configuration window.

In the 'Objects' section of the configuration window, click on 'Import'. This opens a window that lists all available objects that can be added to your desktop.



ObjectBar

This shell replacement software lets you change the look and feel of your Windows environment to resemble popular OS interfaces such as Gnome, Mac OS, QNX, Windows XP, and so on

Changing the style

Launch ObjectBar by right-clicking the ObjectBar icon

in the system tray. From the menu choose **Load > Theme browser**. Select the theme of your choice and click 'OK'. Voila! You will have given a new look to your interface! You can also download new themes from www.wincustomize.com and load them through the theme browser.

WindowBlinds

WindowBlinds adds an



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